

INTERVIEW | PRACHANDA

"I am going to China for the Olympics, don't read much into it"

Nepal's new prime minister, who enjoys a Robin Hood image, led the insurgency for more than a decade and dethroned the 240-year-old monarchy following a people's movement. Soon after the swearing in, he gave an exclusive interview to Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA. Excerpts from the interview.

Q. How does it feel to be the prime minister?

A. I am excited about my new role. I am looking forward to serving the people. The big task will be to provide political stability in Nepal.

Q. It is ironical that you were hiding in a forest earlier and now you are the prime minister. Now the former king Gyanendra stays in a forest.

A. Yes, it is a unique situation. The peace process that has been initiated in Nepal has its own distinct characteristics, and the tremendous change that you see has been possible because of dynamics of our ideology and the support of our people.

Q. As prime minister, your first trip abroad is to China and not India. Is it a signal to India?

A. You have to be clear what my trip is about. Olympics are taking place in China and I am going to attend the closing ceremony since we could not attend the inauguration. It is not a political visit, and not much should be read into it. I am sure our friends in India will understand it. But my first bilateral political visit will be to India.

Q. You have been saying that you want to redefine Indo-Nepal bilateral ties. What is in the offing?

A. The situation has changed. We will still abide by the 12-point understanding that we reached in Delhi, but now the two-pillar theory has changed; Monarchy is not there. It is only the democratic pillar and so we need to factor that in.

Q. India and Nepal always had a close relationship. Will there be any change in the relationship?

A. No, we have traditional, historical and cultural ties with India, which will continue. We will continue to have a special relationship with India.

Q. You face a number of challenges—the economic and security situation is bad, and Nepal needs a degree of political stability. What will be your priority?

A. We will work on a priority basis to draft a new constitution for the country. I want to reach out to the people and work for the economic development of Nepal.



THE NEW RULER: Prachanda at the prime minister's office in Kathmandu

to say but there were enough indications that it will not be business as usual. While there is speculation of a pro-China posture, Prachanda himself is quick to dismiss it. "I am only going to China for the Olympics. My first political visit will be to India," he told INDIA TODAY (see interview).

Perhaps it would be a good sojourn to pick up lessons on growth and governance too. The beleaguered administration is in tatters and the proverbial 100-day honeymoon would be lost in fire-fighting. Indeed his party is yet tagged as a terror group by the US. His biggest problem, while dealing with external or internal exigencies, would be the lack of experience of his team. The pressures are already telling. Earlier this month, young Maoist cadres forced the cancellation of the Miss Nepal beauty pageant. The danger of this young band, which calls itself the Young Communist League, turning into a vigilante army is one of the major concerns both for Prachanda and the Nepalese.

Prachanda's first moves are interesting. His first circle of bodyguards are not from the Nepalese Army but from his People's Liberation Army (PLA). The friction over the integration of this circle with his security apparatus is symbolic of the troubles he will face in addressing the call to merge the PLA with the army. His first big challenge will be to get a new draft constitution in place, which will pave way for the national election. In another time, India would have been the first destination to get help on this. But being a Maoist, this cannot be Prachanda's first option—particularly given "big brother" attitude that his party has often protested about. He realises that pragmatism demands him to keep India on the right side. "Both countries have to work towards a new partnership for a win-win relationship," says Surya Bhusal, president of the Nepal-India Friendship Association. Conventional wisdom calls for India to seize the opportunity and engage with the new regime at full throttle. India should leverage its size and strength to partner Nepal in socio-economic development.

As it seeks to rid the neighbour of terrorist and ISI sleeper cells, an iron-fisted Maoist may be able to deliver better than the motley crew of politicians that have ruled Nepal thus far. ■